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KARAT'S OPTIMISM ABOUT THE THIRD FRONT PLAYING A CRUCIAL POST-POLL ROLE WAS MISPLACED

Great Fall

If it doesn't reinvent itself and chalk out new strategies, the CPI(M)'s future may well be behind it

YEAR	1984	1989	1991	1996	1998	1999	2004	2009
Seats	22 (59)	33 (64)	35 (60)	32 (75)	32 (71)	33 (72)	43 (69)	16 (82)
Vote %	5.87%	6.55%	6.16%	6.12%	5.16%	5.40%	5.66%	5.33%

he assured the party. May 16 showed how out of sync he was with reality.

The Karat camp now argues that the grand Third Front plans had the complete backing of the Party Congress, the CPI(M)'s largest decision-making body. But the front that emerged had little in common with what the Party Congress had endorsed. Parties like the AIADMK of the mercurial Jayalalithaa were the leading lights of the Front. Hush-hush plans that Muslim would vote en masse against the UPA government for striking deals with US and joining hands with Israel came to naught as voters in Muslim-majority constituencies like Ponnani and Manjeri voted overwhelmingly against the CPI(M).

Now the party is dusting off the old debate it had pursued when it decided to withdraw support to the UPA government. West Bengal comrades suggest that the party's withdrawal energised the Congress to team up with Mamata Banerjee. "Only a mad-man can demand that," Kerala CPI(M)

state Secretary Pinarayi Vijayan said when asked about the rumours of a demand for Karat's resignation after the Left's debacle. What makes that clear is that the Kerala unit may stand by the man in the event of a growing demand from the Bengal comrades for his resignation.

Yet the warring camps in the Kerala CPI(M), for diametrically opposite reasons, accuse the central leadership of botching it up. The small but articulate camp led by Chief Minister V.S. Achuthanandan blames the central leadership for condoning the misdeeds of his intra-party rival Vijayan. The powerful state secretary's sides say the Politburo's tolerance shown to the chief minister's blatant violations of party decisions and the consequent disgraces caused for the Government and party have brought about the rout.

The ruling Left Democratic Front (LDF) Government could not have had

a blacker birthday gift as it entered the third year in power two days after its disastrous performance in the 15th Lok Sabha elections. It managed to hold on to barely four of the 20 seats, its worst show since 1991, with all its citadels giving way to the Opposition United Democratic Front (UDF). For the UDF, which grabbed 16 seats, it was a fairytale recovery from 2004 when it had got just a single seat won by the Muslim League and Congress drawing a blank.

The recent run of crises that culminated in the electoral slap in the face should have triggered some introspection, but the CPI(M) is emulating the ostrich in choosing not to look at the writing on the wall. The party is yet to understand the ever-changing notions of politics and if its past behaviour is any indication, the future is set to get bleaker. To avert that tragedy, the CPI(M) will have to reinvent itself after unshackling itself from the half-truths dumped by history.

with M.G. Radhakrishnan